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Familiar ending

Clippers can't finish comeback, fall to Lutheran West again

By MATT GOUL
Morning Journal Writer
ELYRIA — Only coach John Szalay's voice could be heard from the Clearview locker room following a 65-58 Division III district semifinal loss to Lutheran West last night. Then, Miles Nevin emerged, limping on one foot. Nevin was one of 11 seniors to make Clearview's roster at the start of the season. Keeping so many seniors on the roster was a move Szalay admitted all season was a risk, but still one he said he did not regret after it was over last night.

His team finished 16-7, Clearview's most wins since 2002, and a good portion of its fans were still waiting for one final cheer in the Elyria gymnasium after most had left. "I've really never coached a group of kids, one through 13, that have given me so much of their effort, of their heart," Szalay said. "I love this group. I've coached a lot of years and I've coached

some great individuals, but I've never coached a team like this one that gave everything they got." And maybe it was only fitting the Clippers' final game came against Lutheran West (20-1). The Longhorns, when they were senior-laden last year with Illinois-bound Richard Semrau, were pushed to the limit against Clearview at Elyria. The experience was one Szalay and a few of his players pinpointed as one of growth going into this season.

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MORNING JOURNAL/DAVID RICHARD
Clearview's Matt Chonko puts his hands on his head while looking back at an official after a no-call on his shot attempt last night against Lutheran West. The Clippers lost the Division III district semifinal, 65-58.

Falls too strong for Vermilion

By PETE GRASSO
Morning Journal Writer
WESTLAKE — Vermilion's stellar season came to a crashing halt last night as top-seeded Olmsted Falls handed the Sailors a crushing 71-46 loss in the Division II Westlake District semifinals. As the Sailors quietly slumped in the locker room after the game, coach Kurt Habermehl reminded his team, especially the seniors, of the success they had this season.

"(The seniors) are the ones that really laid the groundwork for this basketball team," said Habermehl, whose team won a share of the West Shore Conference. "They're the ones who got us our first conference championship in 16 years. The amount of work they put in is just an incredible example for the younger kids. We're going to be successful down the road because of it."

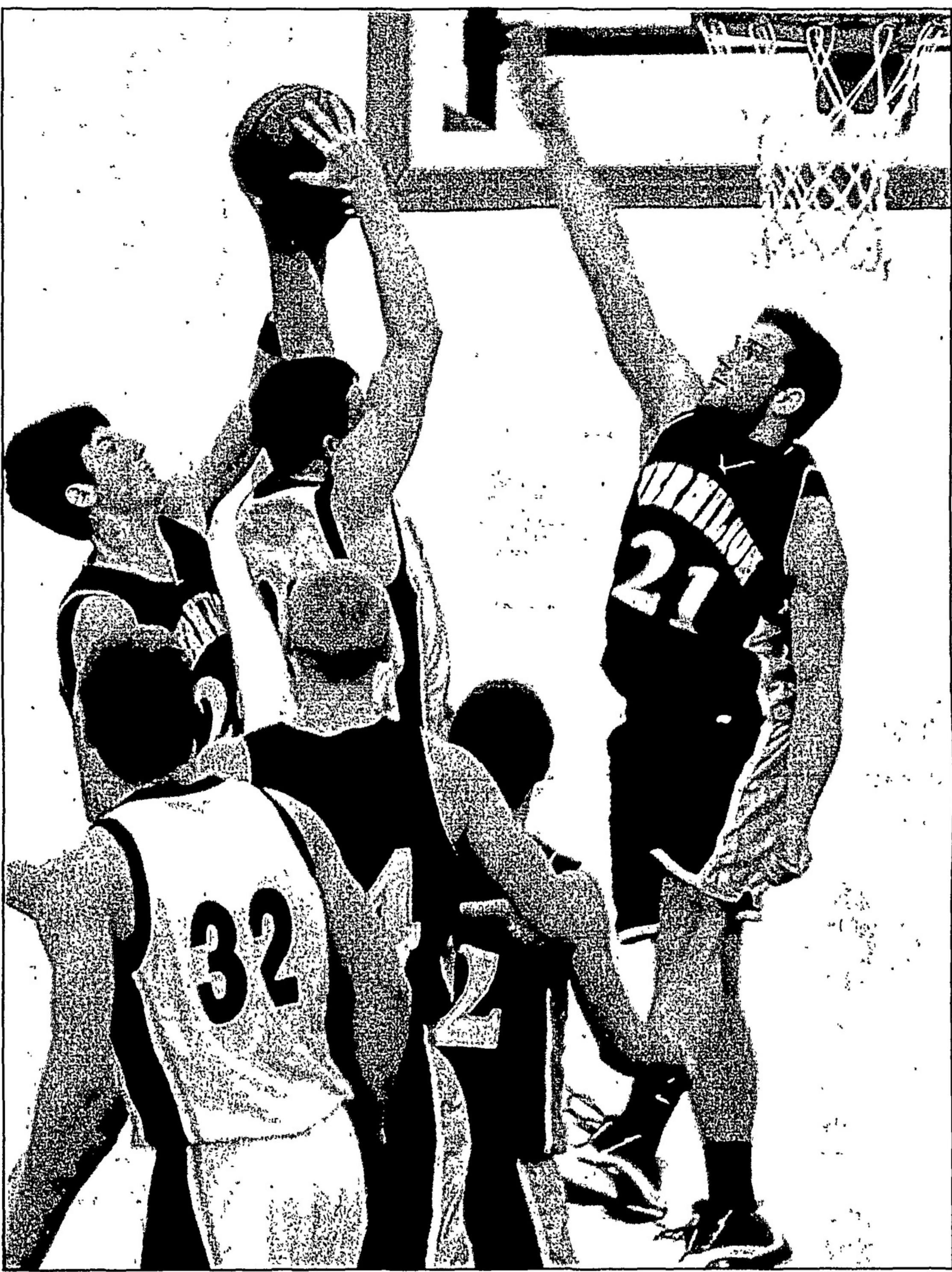
The game was closer than the score indicated. Vermilion fought hard to get within 16-14 at the close of the first quarter.

The Sailors then opened up a 10-6 run in the beginning of the second to give them their first — and only — lead of the night. Colin Voreis sparked the run with two quick layups that kept Falls from running away with the game. "We showed a lot in those first three quarters," Voreis said. "I know that every single person in our locker room is sore ... I know I am. It was a physical game and it's tough to end this way."

At the 4:50 mark in the second quarter, 6-9 senior post Corey Timbs tied the game at 24 with a putback off the glass. Senior guard Kurtis Herchler's two free throws gave the Sailors their only lead.

"I'm so proud of my kids because they played so hard tonight ... they didn't back down at all," Habermehl said.

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MORNING JOURNAL/DAVID RICHARD
Vermilion's Cory Timbs, left, and J.P. Krill, right, attempt to block a shot attempt against Olmsted Falls last night in a Division II district semifinal at Westlake. The Bulldogs won, 71-46.

Lewis headed to town

BROWNS: Former Ravens running back could visit Cleveland as early as today.

By JEFF SCHUDEL
Morning Journal Writer
Free agent running back Jamal Lewis plans to visit the Browns this week, possibly as early as today, now that the Ravens are actively seeking another running back to replace him, according to a source in Baltimore.

Lewis was released last week by Baltimore in a salary cap move, and at the time Ravens general manager Ozzie Newsome said he would like to re-sign Lewis to a more cap-friendly contract. That has not happened, and now the Ravens are talking with the Bills about a possible trade for Willis McGahee. They are also interested in Dominic Rhodes, the free-agent running back from the Colts.

Lewis, 5-11, 245 pounds, has played seven seasons, yet he won't turn 28 until Aug. 28. He carried the ball 314 times for 1,132 yards and nine touchdowns in 2006. The only season he did not gain at least 1,000 yards was in 2005 when he finished with 906 yards.

A year later he set an NFL single-game rushing record against the Browns when he gained 285 yards. He rushed for 205 yards in the other Cleveland-Baltimore game that season, giving him exactly 500 yards against the Browns in a season in which he finished with 2,066.

Browns coach Romeo Crennel has talked about using two running backs the way the Colts did with Rhodes and Joseph Addai. Reuben Droughns, who rushed for 1,232 yards in 2005, is under contract with the Browns through 2009.

Most draft projections have the Browns taking Oklahoma running back Adrian Peterson. Signing Lewis would not necessarily mean the Browns would not draft Peterson, but they would not have Lewis, Peterson and Droughns on the roster.

Growing your own only works if quality is right

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — General manager Mark Shapiro always emphasizes the need for the Indians to constantly grow their own players, because they can't compete financially with the big market heavyweights like the Yankees and Red Sox for the top free agents every year. So how are the Indians doing in that area? Not bad. Not great, but not bad.



Jim Ingraham

Actually, the Indians stack up much better against the other teams in the Central Division than they do against the rest of the American League overall. Let's go to the video tape.

Working off a list that includes the nine projected position starters, the five-man rotation, plus the closer for each American League team, it gives you the 15 most important players on

each team.

On the Indians, four of those 15 players were originally signed and developed by the Indians: Victor Martinez, Johnny Peralta, C.C. Sabathia and Jeremy Sowers.

Among AL Central teams, only the Twins have more home-grown talent in their top 15 than do the Indians. The Twins have five home-grown players among their top 15, including the heart of their batting order, Nos. 3-4-5 hitters Joe Mauer, Michael Cuddyer and Justin Morneau, plus Torii Hunter and Jason Kubel.

Maybe not so coincidentally, the Indians and Twins, combined, have won the Central Division in 10 of the 12 years the division has existed.

Each of the other three teams in the division have just three home-grown products in their top 15 this year, the White Sox (Mark Buehrle, Joe Crede, Brian Anderson), Tigers (Justin Verlander, Brandon Inge, Curtis Granderson) and Royals (Mike Sweeney, David DeJesus, Alex Gordon).

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Slice of Grapefruit

Because of the overflow crowd at yesterday's game with the Yankees, I had to park my car near the shores of Lake Lulu, which is located behind the Indians' clubhouse at Chain O'Lakes Park.

With alligator sightings not uncommon around the lake, when you park near the shore of the lake, you don't linger after you get out of your car. That's just one of the things you learn after you've been on the beat for a while.

And, of course, it goes without saying that under no circumstances should you ever give your car keys to an alligator.

— Jim

More Tribe, C3

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